THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

CHAPTER NINE

“FOUNDING MEMBERS”

July 22 – August 3, 2009
San Diego • Westwood • Burbank

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

COLD OPEN

VARIETY - THURSDAY, JULY 23, 2009

COMIC-CON 2009: MARVEL BRINGS 'IRON MAN 2,' 'THOR' AND 'ANT-MAN' TO HALL H

Saturday's panel will feature the first public appearance of Esther Smilley as Thor, eight days before Edgar Wright's "Ant-Man" opens. Fan lines formed Tuesday night.

FADE IN:

EXT. SAN DIEGO CONVENTION CENTER - HALL H LINE - NIGHT

SUPER: WEDNESDAY, JULY 22, 2009 - 11:50 P.M. PDT

The line is now a small city: tents, folding tables, battery-powered fans. Somebody has brought a generator and a TV playing THE INCREDIBLE HULK on DVD. The SUPERHERO HYPE CREW holds its annual reunion under a canopy with a hand-painted sign: "THE WORTHY."

GARY MORRIS (43) wears a Thor shirt for the first time in his life. PRIYA SHAH (24), now in a PhD program at Caltech, wears a winged Thor helmet over her Wasp hoodie. DARNELL JOHNSON (31) has upgraded to two coolers. TOMMY REYES (21) is reading the Ant-Man tie-in comic by flashlight.

DARNELL
Gary. You're wearing a Thor shirt.

GARY
I watched her test footage forty times. She held that hammer for thirty seconds. I can't hold a gallon of milk for thirty seconds.

PRIYA
Apology #209?

GARY
Posted it at three a.m. on May fifth. Pre-written. I didn't even need to edit it.

TOMMY
(looking up from his comic)
Ant-Man opens next Friday and nobody knows what it's about. The trailers are all Hank in a lab and Janet saying "Hello, Mr. Pym" in a fancy dress. Edgar Wright's hiding something.

PRIYA
Edgar Wright is always hiding something. That's what makes him Edgar Wright.

DARNELL
My question is the panel. Marc-Anthony and Esther Smilley. Same stage. A Donohue and a Smilley. You know what Deadline's calling it?

GARY
"The Handshake."

DARNELL
"The Handshake." Every camera in America is going to be on their hands.

CUT TO:

INT. SAN DIEGO MARRIOTT MARQUIS - MARVEL GREEN ROOM - DAY

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 25, 2009 - 11:15 A.M. PDT

The Marvel suite, now twice the size of 2007's. A craft table with an absurd number of bagels. MARVEL publicists with clipboards. A flat-screen showing the Hall H line from a security camera: six thousand five hundred people waiting.

JON FAVREAU (42), DON CHEADLE (44), HARMONY DIVINE (27) and TAYIA BOYD (27) sit on a couch going over talking points with a publicist. MICKEY ROURKE (56) sits alone in a corner wearing sunglasses and holding a small dog. SAM ROCKWELL (40) is doing a little soft-shoe for no reason.

KEVIN FEIGE (36) and LENORA HAYES (44) stand by the door, watching the hallway.

LENORA
Here's the rule. Desmond Smilley is her manager. He has every right to be backstage. He has no right to be on stage, no right to speak to press on Marvel's behalf, and no right to come within ten feet of Marc-Anthony.

FEIGE
And if he does?

LENORA
Then I'll remind him what happened to Gerald Whitfield.

The door opens. MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (27) enters in jeans and a Tales of Suspense T-shirt, carrying two coffees. AMOND BAKER (27) follows, here as Harmony's boyfriend and absolutely forbidden from going near a microphone.

AMOND
I'm not on the panel. I just want everyone to know I'm not on the panel. I'm here as support. Emotional support.

HARMONY
(from the couch)
You're here because you begged.

AMOND
I'm here because I begged emotionally.

Laughter. Then the door opens again. The room shifts, the way rooms shift when everybody's been waiting for one person.

ESTHER SMILLEY (26) walks in. Black jeans, a simple white blouse, her braid down her back. On her lapel, Cornelius's old gold crown pin. Beside her, a publicist. And behind her, in a perfect cream suit, DESMOND SMILLEY (51).

The room goes quiet. Rockwell stops dancing. Rourke lowers his sunglasses.

Esther's eyes find Marc-Anthony across the room. For half a second, something flickers between them. Then both of them put on their public faces. Feige steps forward.

FEIGE
Esther! Welcome to your first Comic-Con. Mr. Smilley, good to see you.

DESMOND
(cool smile)
Kevin.

FEIGE
I'd like to introduce you both to everyone. This is Jon, Don, Harmony, Tayia, Mickey, Sam...

(beat)
...and Marc-Anthony Bullock.

Marc-Anthony crosses the room. He stops in front of Esther. Every person in the room is watching. He holds out his hand.

MARC-ANTHONY
(perfectly polite)
Esther. It's really nice to meet you. Congratulations on Thor.

ESTHER
(perfectly polite, shaking his hand)
Thank you. It's nice to meet you too.

Amond, by the bagel table, freezes mid-bite.

AMOND
(loudly, confused, mouth full)
Meet? What do you mean, "meet"? Y'all have been texting every night since...

Harmony grabs his arm and drives her heel into his foot in one fluid, dance-trained motion. Amond doubles over.

AMOND (CONT'D)
(wheezing)
...since... the Kids' Choice Awards... in 1994... when they met... probably. I don't know. I'm the Hulk. I have a head injury.

A long, terrible silence. Desmond's eyes move slowly from Amond to Marc-Anthony to Esther. Esther's face is a perfect mask. Marc-Anthony doesn't blink.

MARC-ANTHONY
(lightly)
We did meet at the '94 Kids' Choice Awards. I was eleven and she was eleven. I think I asked to borrow a pencil.

ESTHER
(smoothly)
He never gave it back.

Polite laughter from the room. Feige jumps in.

FEIGE
Okay! Mr. Smilley, would you like to meet Mr. Bullock as well?

Marc-Anthony turns to Desmond. This is the first time the two of them have ever been in the same room. Marc-Anthony holds out his hand, warm and open.

MARC-ANTHONY
Mr. Smilley. I grew up watching you in SOUTHERN HEAT. My mom wouldn't let me stay up for it, so Elxa and I used to sneak downstairs and watch it with the sound turned way down. You were the coolest man on television.

Desmond looks at the outstretched hand. He doesn't move. Five seconds. Six. The room holds its breath.

A Marvel staff photographer in the corner raises a camera. Desmond sees it. Slowly, with the smile of a man who has spent thirty years knowing where the cameras are, he takes Marc-Anthony's hand.

DESMOND
(smooth, ice beneath)
Mr. Bullock. Your grandfather must be very proud.

MARC-ANTHONY
He's proud of a lot of people, Mr. Smilley. I hope he gets to be proud of your daughter too.

Desmond's grip tightens for a fraction of a second. Then he lets go.

Behind him, Esther meets Marc-Anthony's eyes over her father's shoulder. She doesn't smile. She doesn't have to.

CUT TO:

INT. SAN DIEGO CONVENTION CENTER - HALL H - DAY

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 25, 2009 - 1:00 P.M. PDT

Six thousand five hundred people. The roar when Feige walks out is deafening, and so is the chant, older now, a tradition: "NO-BO-DY! NO-BO-DY!"

FEIGE
Three years ago, I promised you nobody would get nerfed. Today I'm going to show you three movies that keep that promise. Let's start with the man who started it all!

The IRON MAN 2 cast walks out to a tidal wave of noise: Favreau, Cheadle, Harmony, Tayia, Rockwell, Rourke (still holding his dog), and Marc-Anthony, last, arms raised.

The footage plays: Tony Stark in a Formula One race in Monaco, filmed on the actual street circuit. Whiplash (Rourke) walking through fire with electric whips, slicing a real race car in half. Rhodey in the silver Mark II armor (War Machine) firing a mini-gun. Natasha Romanoff (Harmony) dismantling a hallway of guards in one unbroken take, every move her own.

Hall H loses its mind. Darnell, in the third row, is on his feet.

DARNELL
WAR MACHINE! WAR MACHINE!

On stage, Cheadle leans into his mic.

CHEADLE
I want to say something. Terrence Howard built this role, and I'm standing on his shoulders. And when I took it, the first person who called me was this guy.

(pointing at Marc-Anthony)
He said, "Welcome to the Air Force, Colonel." Every day on set, he called me Colonel.

The hall applauds warmly. Marc-Anthony puts a hand on Cheadle's shoulder.

FAN AT MIC (TEENAGE BOY, 14)
Harmony, did you really do all your own fighting?

HARMONY
Every move. I spent fifteen years on Broadway learning to land on eight. Now I land on a guy's face on eight.

Huge laughter and cheers. In the audience, Amond, seated with the families in a reserved section, stands up and cheers louder than anyone. A camera finds him; he gets a roar of his own and sits down, embarrassed.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - STAGE - LATER

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 25, 2009 - 1:40 P.M. PDT

The Iron Man 2 cast has taken their seats. Feige returns to center stage. The lights dim. Thunder rolls through the speakers, as it did last year.

FEIGE
Last year, I brought you a hammer. This year, I brought you the woman who's going to lift it.

(beat)
Directed by Kenneth Branagh. Ladies and gentlemen... Loki! Tom Hiddleston!

TOM HIDDLESTON (28) bounds out, bows theatrically, and blows a kiss to the crowd. Huge cheers. KENNETH BRANAGH (48) follows to a standing ovation. Then Feige raises his hand.

FEIGE (CONT'D)
And the God of Thunder... Esther Smilley!

Esther walks out from the wings.

Half a beat of silence. Six thousand five hundred people taking in America's sweetheart, the nun, the Shirley Temple girl.

Then she walks to the center of the stage, where a hydraulic platform is rising out of the fog. On it, on its black stone pedestal, the forged MJOLNIR. "IF SHE BE WORTHY."

Last year, the hammer was bolted down as a gag. Marc-Anthony couldn't lift it. Nobody could.

Esther stands in front of it. She closes her eyes. Breathes. Opens them. She wraps her hand around the leather handle.

And she lifts it. In one smooth, impossible motion, high above her head, the stage lights catching the runes. (The bolts were removed the night before. Only Feige and Branagh knew.)

Hall H DETONATES. A sound like a stadium. People jumping on chairs. Priya, in her winged helmet, is screaming and sobbing at the same time. Gary has both hands on his head. A man in a "BOYCOTT FEMALE THOR" T-shirt in row twelve is on his feet, clapping, crying, and looking confused about it.

On the Iron Man 2 side of the stage, Marc-Anthony jumps out of his chair, pointing at her and shouting into his mic.

MARC-ANTHONY
SHE'S WORTHY! I CALLED IT! I WAS NOT WORTHY! SHE IS WORTHY!

Esther lowers the hammer and turns to the crowd, breathing hard, overwhelmed. She leans into the mic.

ESTHER
(her voice catching)
Hi.

A wave of laughter and love from the crowd.

ESTHER (CONT'D)
A year ago I watched this hammer rise out of this floor on TV, sitting on my sister's bedroom floor. And I said I wanted it so badly I couldn't breathe.

(beat)
I can breathe now.

The applause is overwhelming. Branagh puts an arm around her. Hiddleston kneels at her feet in mock fealty. The crowd chants: "THOR! THOR! THOR!"

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - Q AND A - CONTINUOUS

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 25, 2009 - 1:55 P.M. PDT

At the audience mic: Priya, in the winged helmet. Shaking.

PRIYA
Hi, Kevin. It's me. Again.

FEIGE
(laughing)
My favorite fan. Every year.

PRIYA
This one's for Esther. Last year I told Kevin I never thought I could be Thor. I'm getting my PhD in physics at Caltech now. I'm the only woman in my cohort.

(beat)
What do you want little girls to feel when they see you pick up that hammer?

Esther looks at her for a long moment.

ESTHER
I want them to feel like nobody gets to decide what they're worthy of except them.

(beat, a small smile)
And I want them to know that you can learn Shakespeare from your grandfather and boxing from a man on Crenshaw, and both of them count.

Thunderous applause. Priya stumbles back from the mic into Darnell's arms, crying.

Next at the mic: a nervous TEENAGE GIRL (16) in a homemade Thor costume.

TEENAGE GIRL
Question for Marc-Anthony and Esther. When Iron Man and Thor meet in the comics, they fight. Are you guys going to fight?

The hall laughs and cheers. Marc-Anthony and Esther, on opposite ends of the stage, look at each other. A long beat.

MARC-ANTHONY
I mean, I'd lose. She's a god. I'm a guy in a can.

ESTHER
(leaning in, deadpan)
He'd lose.

Laughter roars through the hall. Then Marc-Anthony, unable to help himself, adds:

MARC-ANTHONY
For the record, she's already beaten me once. At the 1994 Kids' Choice Awards she took my pencil and never gave it back.

ESTHER
(without missing a beat)
It was a good pencil.

The crowd erupts. In the reserved section, Desmond, standing at the back with his arms folded, watches his daughter laugh on stage, a real, unguarded laugh, at something Marc-Anthony Bullock said. His face is stone.

Beside him, Lenora appears out of nowhere, her arms folded too.

LENORA
(pleasantly, not looking at him)
They have great chemistry. Very marketable.

DESMOND
(not looking at her)
They met an hour ago.

LENORA
Mm-hm.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL H - STAGE - CONTINUOUS

Feige, back at the podium.

FEIGE
One more thing before we go. In six days, a little movie about a very small man opens in theaters. Please welcome Edgar Wright, Joe Cornish, David Tipton and Elxa Bullock!

EDGAR WRIGHT (35) and JOE CORNISH (40) bound out, followed by DAVID TIPTON (28), now in a much nicer suit, and ELXA BULLOCK (28), in a gold dress that matches the brooch. The crowd gives them a huge welcome.

EDGAR WRIGHT
We've kept this film under wraps because Kevin doesn't let us have fun. But since it's coming out in six days, here are two minutes.

The lights go down. The footage: HANK PYM in a cluttered lab, shrinking for the first time, falling into a carpet that looks like a jungle. A real ant colony, shot with macro lenses in real dirt. Hank riding a carpenter ant through a bathtub drain like a rodeo cowboy. Janet van Dyne in her father's laboratory, standing over his body, killed by an ALIEN CREATURE from another dimension, a horrifying, practical, animatronic monster.

ELXA (ON SCREEN, AS JANET)
Dr. Pym. You said you could make a person small. Make me something that can sting.

Hank and Janet shrinking side by side. Janet's wings burst from her back for the first time, translucent, shimmering. The audience gasps.

EGGHEAD: a bald, brilliant, terrifying genius, played by PAUL GIAMATTI, holding Hank in a glass jar like an insect. "Little man. Big ego."

Black. ANT-MAN. JULY 31.

The crowd roars. Tommy, in the front rows, is shaking his head in disbelief.

TOMMY
(to Gary)
The alien that killed her dad. That's TALES TO ASTONISH #44. Her real origin. And EGGHEAD. Ant-Man's actual archenemy. Edgar did the real stuff.

GARY
Of course he did. Nobody gets nerfed.

CUT TO:

MONTAGE - "THE HANDSHAKE" GOES VIRAL

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 25 - SUNDAY, JULY 26, 2009

DEADLINE HOLLYWOOD DAILY - SATURDAY, JULY 25, 2009, 4:12 PM PT

THE HANDSHAKE: DESMOND SMILLEY AND MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK SHAKE ON IT - BARELY

I'm told it lasted three seconds backstage. A Marvel staff photographer captured it. Desmond Smilley, a man whose family has feuded with the Donohues for four decades, shaking the hand of Victor Donohue's grandson. One witness: "You could have chilled a bottle of champagne on that handshake." Meanwhile, on stage, his daughter and the Donohue boy had more chemistry than the entire cast of TWILIGHT.

YOUTUBE.COM - "ESTHER SMILLEY LIFTS MJOLNIR - HALL H 2009 (CROWD GOES INSANE)" - uploaded by hallh_bootleg_09 - 3,412,885 views

Top comment - ThorOdinson4Ever: I made a boycott group last year. I was in Hall H. I cried. I deleted the group. She is worthy.

YOUTUBE.COM - "MARC-ANTHONY AND ESTHER SMILLEY: 'HE'D LOSE' + PENCIL STORY" - 2,108,334 views

Top comment - iamironwoman: "it was a good pencil" WHY DO I FEEL LIKE THERE'S A WHOLE MOVIE HAPPENING HERE THAT WE'RE NOT SEEING

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "ESTHER LIFTED THE HAMMER. HALL H 2009 DISCUSSION" (Page 1 of 391)

NoNerfsPlz (Jul 25, 2:20 PM)
THE BOLTS WERE REMOVED. Last year it was bolted down so nobody could lift it. This year she lifted it. Kevin Feige planned this for TWELVE MONTHS. I'm going to need a minute.

ShellHead1963 (Jul 25, 2:35 PM)
The boycott guy next to me in row 12 cried. I cried. We hugged. We're friends now. His name is Doug. Doug is a good man.

Gamma_Gamma_Hey (Jul 25, 3:01 PM)
Ant-Man footage: Tales to Astonish #44 origin for the Wasp, EGGHEAD as the villain, real ants shot with macro lenses. Edgar Wright made the most comic-accurate Ant-Man possible.

Repulsor_Ray (Jul 25, 3:30 PM)
Can we talk about how Amond Baker almost said "Y'ALL HAVE BEEN TEXTING" in the green room? There's a rumor going around from a Marvel intern. Somebody stepped on his foot. I need to know what he was going to say.

WarMachineRox (Jul 25, 3:44 PM)
The Hulk can't keep a secret. If Amond knows something, we'll all know it in like six months.

TWITTER.COM - TRENDING TOPICS (WORLDWIDE) - SATURDAY, JULY 25, 2009

#SheIsWorthy - #HallH - The Handshake - Esther Smilley - #AntMan - Mjolnir - Kids Choice Awards 1994

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE

amondbaker: i did not say anything in the green room. i was eating a bagel. my foot is fine. harmony is a very good dancer 4:40 PM Jul 25th from web

harmonydivine: @amondbaker you're welcome 4:42 PM Jul 25th from web

marcanthonyb: got beaten by a god at comic con. for the second time. first time was a pencil in 1994. #SheIsWorthy 6:15 PM Jul 25th from web

esthersmilley: hi. i just made a twitter. thank you hall h. thank you granddaddy. i can breathe. #SheIsWorthy 9:00 PM Jul 25th from web

CUT TO:

EXT. SAN DIEGO MARRIOTT MARQUIS - SERVICE STAIRWELL - NIGHT

SUPER: SATURDAY, JULY 25, 2009 - 11:45 P.M. PDT

A concrete stairwell between the 18th and 19th floors. Fluorescent hum. Esther sits on the steps, shoes off, still in her blouse, holding her phone. The door above opens. Marc-Anthony slips in, closes it quietly behind him, and sits two steps below her.

ESTHER
We can't do this here. My father's room is on eighteen.

MARC-ANTHONY
I know. That's why I took the stairs from twenty.

A beat. For the first time, there's no phone between them. Just the two of them, in a stairwell, at midnight.

ESTHER
"I asked to borrow a pencil."

MARC-ANTHONY
It's true. I did.

ESTHER
You did not. You asked me if I wanted to sneak out of the green room and steal all the green slime sundaes from the craft table. We ate eleven. I threw up on Kenan Thompson's shoes.

MARC-ANTHONY
(laughing)
I was protecting your reputation. America's sweetheart doesn't throw up on Kenan.

They laugh quietly. Then it fades.

ESTHER
Amond almost...

MARC-ANTHONY
I know. I'm sorry. He found out about "Pastor Williams" at the Hulk premiere. He's been holding it in for a year. That's a world record for Amond.

ESTHER
My father heard him.

MARC-ANTHONY
Your father heard a man with a head injury.

ESTHER
(shaking her head)
You don't know him. He heard. He's going to start pulling the thread.

Marc-Anthony looks at her. Then he reaches into his pocket and pulls out a yellow No. 2 pencil, the kind from an elementary school. He holds it out.

MARC-ANTHONY
I owe you this. Fifteen years late.

Esther stares at the pencil. Then at him. She takes it.

ESTHER
(very softly)
You're ridiculous.

MARC-ANTHONY
I'm aware.

A long moment. They're close now. Closer than they've ever been. Neither moves.

Somewhere below, a door opens. Footsteps on the stairs. Esther jumps up, grabs her shoes, and with one last look, disappears through the eighteenth-floor door.

Marc-Anthony sits alone in the stairwell. A HOTEL SECURITY GUARD (50s) comes around the landing, flashlight in hand. He stops and recognizes him.

SECURITY GUARD
...Mr. Stark?

MARC-ANTHONY
Just getting my steps in.

SECURITY GUARD
(looking at the door, then back at him)
At midnight?

MARC-ANTHONY
I'm very dedicated to fitness.

The guard looks at him for a long beat, then shrugs and keeps walking. Marc-Anthony puts his head back against the concrete wall and closes his eyes, smiling.

CUT TO:

EXT. MANN VILLAGE THEATRE - WESTWOOD - NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, JULY 28, 2009 - 6:30 P.M. PDT - THE ANT-MAN PREMIERE

The iconic white Spanish Mission tower glows above Westwood Village. The red carpet has been decorated as a giant ant tunnel. Paramount and Marvel banners. Fans pack the streets.

ELXA BULLOCK (28) steps onto the carpet in a gold and black gown, an exact couture replica of Janet van Dyne's gala dress. Flashbulbs explode. Behind her: NATASHA (48), ROBERT (50), VICTOR (73), JOAN (71), GRACE (15) and MARC-ANTHONY. The whole Donohue-Bullock family, again, at a Marvel premiere.

An ACCESS HOLLYWOOD CORRESPONDENT pushes a mic toward Natasha.

ACCESS HOLLYWOOD CORRESPONDENT
Natasha! Two years ago your daughter kept this role a secret from you. How does it feel tonight?

NATASHA
(radiant, controlled)
It feels like I raised a daughter who doesn't need me. Which is the best and worst feeling a mother can have.

Elxa, overhearing, turns and hugs her mother right there on the carpet. Cameras go wild. Further down, DAVID TIPTON (28) stands with his mother, MRS. LORETTA TIPTON (60), a retired schoolteacher from Fresno, who is clutching his arm and staring at everything.

LORETTA TIPTON
David, there's a man here dressed as an ant.

DAVID
There are a lot of men here dressed as ants, Mom.

LORETTA TIPTON
Two years ago you told me you got promoted at Fry's.

DAVID
I know, Mom.

LORETTA TIPTON
(eyes filling)
This is a much better promotion.

CUT TO:

INT. MANN VILLAGE THEATRE - AUDITORIUM - NIGHT

SUPER: TUESDAY, JULY 28, 2009 - 9:05 P.M. PDT

The climax on screen. Hank Pym and Janet van Dyne, shrunk to the size of insects, ride a swarm of flying ants into Egghead's laboratory. The Wasp darts through a laser grid on shimmering wings, stinging Egghead's henchmen with bio-electric blasts. Hank commands a real army of ants through his cybernetic helmet. Egghead (Giamatti) screams, swatting at nothing.

The audience is roaring with laughter and cheering at once.

On screen, the battle won, Janet lands on Hank's shoulder, tiny, and grins.

ELXA (ON SCREEN, AS JANET)
We should do this professionally. We need a name. Something colorful. Something that makes the bad guys nervous.

DAVID (ON SCREEN, AS HANK)
Like what?

ELXA (ON SCREEN, AS JANET)
I'll think of something.

The comic book fans in the theater SCREAM. They know exactly what she's going to name.

INT. MANN VILLAGE THEATRE - AUDITORIUM - LATER

SUPER: TUESDAY, JULY 28, 2009 - 9:22 P.M. PDT

The credits have ended. Nobody has left. Nobody ever leaves a Marvel movie anymore.

On screen: HANK'S LAB, night. Hank and Janet, exhausted and laughing, eating Chinese food on the floor. A shadow falls across them. A voice from the doorway.

NICK FURY (ON SCREEN)
Dr. Pym. Miss van Dyne. You two have been busy.

SAMUEL L. JACKSON steps into the light: eyepatch, leather coat.

DAVID (ON SCREEN, AS HANK)
(dropping his chopsticks)
Who are you? How did you get in here?

NICK FURY (ON SCREEN)
I get in everywhere, Doc. That's the job.

(to Janet)
I'm putting together a group of people with unusual talents. Some of them are already on my list.

(beat)
I'd like the two of you to be founding members.

Janet looks at Hank. A slow, delighted smile.

ELXA (ON SCREEN, AS JANET)
Founding members of what?

Fury just smiles. Black screen. "ANT-MAN AND THE WASP WILL RETURN."

The theater ERUPTS. People are on their feet. In the family section, Victor Donohue is clapping hard. Grace screams "FOUNDING MEMBERS!" Elxa, in her seat, has both hands over her face.

MARC-ANTHONY
(leaning over, whispering to Elxa)
Founding member. You outrank me now.

ELXA
(through tears)
Technically we're the same rank.

MARC-ANTHONY
No. You're a founding member. I'm just a guy Fury yelled at in my living room.

CUT TO:

MONTAGE - FRIDAY, JULY 31, 2009: ANT-MAN OPENS

SUPER: FRIDAY, JULY 31, 2009 - 12:01 A.M. TO 11:59 P.M. PDT

SUPERHEROHYPE.COM - THREAD: "OFFICIAL ANT-MAN DISCUSSION - SPOILERS" (Page 1 of 256)
Gamma_Gamma_Hey (Jul 31, 12:20 AM) "We need a name. Something colorful." SHE NAMES THE TEAM IN AVENGERS #1. Edgar Wright planted it. I can't breathe.
NoNerfsPlz (Jul 31, 12:28 AM) FURY SAID FOUNDING MEMBERS. Iron Man, Hulk, Ant-Man, Wasp. Thor is coming. This is AVENGERS #1. It's happening. It's actually happening.
ShellHead1963 (Jul 31, 12:45 AM) The ant rodeo through the bathtub drain is the funniest scene in any superhero movie ever. Real ants. Macro lens. Practical. Edgar is a lunatic genius.
WarMachineRox (Jul 31, 1:02 AM) Delroy Lindo as Janet's father in that opening scene broke me. The alien killing him is from Tales to Astonish #44. They didn't skip the dark stuff.
Repulsor_Ray (Jul 31, 1:30 AM) Paul Giamatti as Egghead is the most terrifying bald man since Jeff Bridges in Iron Man.
Mjolnir_Worthy (Jul 31, 9:15 AM) Four movies. Four post-credits scenes. Iron Man meets Fury. Hulk: Tony recruits. Ant-Man: Fury recruits Hank and Janet. Next is Iron Man 2, then Thor. They're assembling the team in front of our eyes.

FACEBOOK - GROUP: "MARVEL IS MAKING THE AVENGERS (CONFIRMED BY NICK FURY)" - 1,204,377 members

Wall post - Jordan K. (University of Michigan, '09): Updated chart. FOUNDING AVENGERS (Avengers #1, 1963): Iron Man (Marc-Anthony Bullock) - DONE. Hulk (Amond Baker) - DONE. Ant-Man (David Tipton) - DONE. Wasp (Elxa Bullock) - DONE. Thor (Esther Smilley) - CAST, May 2011. CAPTAIN AMERICA (Avengers #4) - ???. We're one Cap away.

TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE

edgarwright: six years. one tiny man. one perfect wasp. one terrifying egghead. thank you everyone who went to the ant documentary. #AntMan 12:40 AM Jul 31st from web

elxabullock: founding member. i'm going to need that on a t-shirt. thank you to everyone who saw us tonight. thank you mom. #AntMan 1:15 AM Jul 31st from web

davidtipton: to everyone at fry's electronics burbank: i'm sorry i quit with no notice. please go see my movie. i'll buy you all ram 2:05 AM Jul 31st from web

amondbaker: ant man was incredible. i want to say something about the post credit scene but harmony is holding my phone and my foot 3:30 AM Jul 31st from web

CUT TO:

DEADLINE HOLLYWOOD DAILY - SATURDAY, AUGUST 1, 2009, 9:20 AM PT

ANT-MAN NOT SO SMALL: $21.2M FRIDAY! MARVEL GOES FOUR-FOR-FOUR

Tiny man, huge numbers. Edgar Wright's ANT-MAN is shrinking the competition with a $21.2M Friday, including midnight shows. It's on track for a $58M+ weekend. A character most moviegoers had never heard of two years ago is beating tracking by fifteen million dollars. CinemaScore: "A." Rotten Tomatoes: 92%. Paramount is giddy. And over in Burbank, I'm told, a certain CEO watched the numbers very, very closely.

CUT TO:

INT. DONOHUE ENTERTAINMENT - NATASHA BULLOCK'S OFFICE - BURBANK - DAY

SUPER: SUNDAY, AUGUST 2, 2009 - 4:00 P.M. PDT

A quiet Sunday on the lot. Natasha (48), in casual clothes, sits at her desk with a single sheet in front of her. Box office: ANT-MAN - $58.4M OPENING WEEKEND. Beside it, a thick, bound document stamped "STRICTLY CONFIDENTIAL - PROJECT ASGARD."

Victor (73) sits in the chair across from her, cane across his knees. Behind them, through the window, the Mickey Mouse water tower glows in the late sun.

NATASHA
Four films. Four hits. Iron Man, three hundred and eighteen million domestic. Hulk, one hundred and seventy-two. Ant-Man, fifty-eight million this weekend and climbing. And the Avengers. The fans have figured out the Avengers.

VICTOR
And their stock?

NATASHA
Still recovering from the crash. Undervalued. Perlmutter knows it. He knows the other studios are circling. Warner. Sony. Even Fox.

VICTOR
(dry)
Fox would pay anything to keep the X-Men. And they'd pay double for everything else.

NATASHA
Which is why I want to move first. Four billion dollars. Cash and stock. We announce at the end of the month.

Victor looks at the document for a long time.

VICTOR
Your son. Your daughter. The Smilley girl. All of them under the Donohue roof.

NATASHA
All of them earned it without us. We're not buying their jobs, Daddy. We're buying the house they built.

VICTOR
And when you tell Marc-Anthony?

Natasha hesitates. For the first time in the conversation, the CEO looks like a mother.

NATASHA
He's going to think I'm taking it from him.

VICTOR
Are you?

NATASHA
(quietly)
I'm going to make sure nobody else ever can.

She picks up her BlackBerry. Scrolls to a number. "PERLMUTTER, I." Her thumb hovers over it.

VICTOR
Tasha.

She looks up.

VICTOR (CONT'D)
Tell him before the world does. Learn from my mistakes. Don't let him read it in Variety.

Natasha looks at her father. She knows he's not just talking about Marc-Anthony. She doesn't know what else he's talking about. Not yet.

She presses CALL.

NATASHA
(into the phone, cool and precise)
Ike. Natasha Bullock. I'd like to set a meeting.

SMASH CUT TO BLACK.

MONDAY HEADLINES

SUPER: MONDAY, AUGUST 3, 2009

VARIETY - MON AUG 3, 2009

'ANT-MAN' STINGS WITH $58.4M; MARVEL'S UNIVERSE NOW 4-FOR-4

Wright's comic-accurate caper stars Tipton and Bullock as founding Avengers; post-credits Fury scene all but confirms an ensemble film. "G.I. Joe" opens Friday facing a smaller, angrier foe.

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER - MON AUG 3, 2009

FROM FRY'S TO FOUNDING AVENGER: DAVID TIPTON'S IMPROBABLE OPENING WEEKEND

"I used to sell computer memory. Now my face is on a lunchbox. A real one. Not a metaphor."

ENTERTAINMENT WEEKLY - COVER (Issue of Aug. 14, 2009)

THE WORTHY: Esther Smilley Lifts the Hammer

Inside: Hall H's loudest moment ever, Shakespeare lessons in the garage, and the handshake heard 'round Hollywood.

JET MAGAZINE - "PEOPLE ARE TALKING ABOUT" (Issue of Aug. 17, 2009)

Elxa Bullock: Founding Member

Plus: Amond Baker's green-room slip. What was he about to say about Marc-Anthony Bullock and Esther Smilley? Insiders are... "texting."

FADE OUT.

END OF CHAPTER NINE